



What We Mean by Protecting Them

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 Start where almost everyone already stands. A child is not a small adult, and the people who raise children owe them some shelter from what they are not ready to carry. No serious person disputes that some material belongs to a later year, that a parent may reasonably want a say in what a nine-year-old meets on a library shelf, that protection is a real duty and not a pretext invented to control. Grant all of it. The argument that follows does not need to take any of it back.

2 It needs only to ask what, precisely, the protecting is protecting from. There is a kind of harm a child can suffer from a book, and there is the discomfort a child, or more often an adult, feels at encountering a life unlike their own; these are not the same thing, and the whole question turns on whether we keep them apart. [Juxtaposition] The shared premise was that children deserve protection from harm. It was never that children deserve protection from difference. [Antithesis] If the premise is the first, the conclusion arrives uninvited.

3 Look at what is actually being pulled. And Tango Makes Three is a picture book about two male penguins who raise a chick together; it contains nothing a censor could honestly call obscene, and it has been among the most challenged books in the country. [Logos] The stated reason for removal in 2025 was, repeatedly, the protection of minors from illegal obscenity, alongside objections to LGBTQIA+ characters and to coverage of race and racism. When the obscenity charge is leveled at a book whose offense is two penguins, the charge is doing other work. Of 4,235 titles challenged last year, 1,671, about forty percent, told the stories of LGBTQIA+ people and people of color. [Anecdotal vs statistical evidence]

4 There is a second tell, in who is doing the challenging. The romantic picture is a worried parent at a board meeting. The record from the American Library Association says otherwise: in 2025, ninety-two percent of challenges came from pressure groups and government officials, up from seventy-two the year before, and fewer than three percent from individual parents. [Logos] The three most challenged titles, for what it is worth, were Sold, The Perks of Being a Wallflower, and Gender Queer. [Syntax] A duty that began in one household has been handed to organized campaigns, and 5,668 books were pulled from libraries on its authority.

5 So the shared premise, followed honestly, lands somewhere the premise-holder did not mean to go. Protection from harm is a duty. Protection from the existence of other people is something else, and the cost of it is not borne by the adults who feel safer. It is borne by the child who never finds the one book that said her life was possible, and by every child, hers included, who grows up having practiced the narrow habit of mistaking unfamiliarity for danger. That habit does not stay in the library. We were trying to keep them safe. It is worth wondering what we taught them instead.

Devices, and why they are here:

Juxtaposition (paragraph 2): “There is a kind of harm a child can suffer from a book, and there is the discomfort a child, or more often an adult, feels at encountering a life unlike their own; these are not the same thing, and the whole question turns on whether we keep them apart.”

Sets the harm-to-a-child against the mere discomfort of encountering an unlike life, side by side in one sentence, so the reader feels the two are being conflated before the argument names the conflation. It is the hinge the whole dialectic turns on.

Antithesis (paragraph 2): “The shared premise was that children deserve protection from harm. It was never that children deserve protection from difference.”

Balances protection-from-harm against protection-from-difference in parallel form to crystallize the distinction the chain depends on; the symmetry is reserved for this one load-bearing contrast rather than used as background cadence.

Logos (paragraph 3): “And Tango Makes Three is a picture book about two male penguins who raise a chick together; it contains nothing a censor could honestly call obscene, and it has been among the most challenged books in the country.”

Reasons from a concrete particular (a children's book with no obscene content yet heavily challenged) to the inference that the stated rationale is a cover, letting evidence rather than assertion carry the claim, which is the register's spine.

Anecdotal vs statistical evidence (paragraph 3): “Of 4,235 titles challenged last year, 1,671, about forty percent, told the stories of LGBTQIA+ people and people of color.”

Pivots deliberately from the single Tango example to the forty-percent figure, pairing the one vivid case with the aggregate so neither stands alone; the choice of both evidence types is the persuasive move.

Logos (paragraph 4): “The record from the American Library Association says otherwise: in 2025, ninety-two percent of challenges came from pressure groups and government officials, up from seventy-two the year before, and fewer than three percent from individual parents.”

Uses the ALA data on who initiates challenges (92 percent groups and officials, under 3 percent parents) to dismantle the sympathetic image of the worried lone parent through reasoning from numbers, not emotion.

Syntax (paragraph 4): “The three most challenged titles, for what it is worth, were Sold, The Perks of Being a Wallflower, and Gender Queer.”

Drops the inert, off-thesis ranking of the three most-challenged titles into a clipped aside (with the throwaway tag for what it is worth) so the paragraph carries a detail that does not advance the argument, roughening the surface against tidy machine prose.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the writer introduces And Tango Makes Three primarily in order to
 - A) argue that all obscenity objections to library books are made in bad faith
 - B) expose a gap between the stated rationale for removal and the books actually being targeted
 - C) praise the literary quality of a book that has been unfairly removed
 - D) establish that picture books are more frequently challenged than other genres

2. In context, the closing sentences ('We were trying to keep them safe. It is worth wondering what we taught them instead.') best convey which of the following about the writer's tone?

- A) triumphant, having decisively won the argument against the other side
- B) restrained and rueful, declining to accuse while letting the consequence settle on the reader
- C) neutral and detached, reporting the outcome without any evaluative stance
- D) indignant and accusatory, condemning parents for deliberate cruelty

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer B. The writer pairs the penguin book with the official obscenity rationale to show the charge is doing other work, an inference about the gap between stated reason and real target. The genre-frequency option is true-but-not-the-function-asked: the passage never claims picture books are challenged more than other genres. The all-obscenity-in-bad-faith option is over-broad, extending the single example into an absolute the text does not assert. The literary-praise option targets the wrong effect: the writer uses the book as evidence of mistargeting, not to evaluate its merit.

2. Answer B. The short concessive 'We were trying to keep them safe' grants good intent, and 'It is worth wondering' withholds the verdict, producing a measured, regretful close. The triumphant option misreads the inward, unresolved turn as a victory lap, which the soft 'worth wondering' rules out. The neutral-detached option ignores the clear evaluative weight of 'what we taught them instead.' The indignant-accusatory option inverts the tone: the writer credits sincere protective intent rather than charging deliberate cruelty.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer concedes at the outset that protecting children is a genuine duty, then argues the duty is being misapplied. Does granting that opening ground make the later argument more persuasive, or does it concede too much? Point to specific sentences.
2. The piece distinguishes 'protection from harm' from 'protection from difference.' Is that distinction always clear in practice, or are there real cases where the two are hard to separate? Where might a thoughtful parent and the writer genuinely disagree?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The concession strengthens the argument rather than weakening it. By granting in the first paragraph that 'a child is not a small adult' and that protection is 'a real duty and not a pretext,' the writer removes the easiest rebuttal, namely that the piece is hostile to parents. Because the reader has already agreed to the premise, the turn in paragraph two ('what, precisely, the protecting is protecting from') feels like a consequence the reader signed up for rather than an attack. The dialectic only works because the starting ground is shared, so the generous concession is the engine, not a cost.

2. The harm-versus-difference line is sharp on the page but blurrier in practice, and the writer half-admits this by choosing the cleanest possible example. And Tango Makes Three is easy because two penguins raising a chick is obviously not obscene, so the gap between stated reason and real target is stark. A harder case might be a young-adult memoir that includes both lived LGBTQIA+ experience and frank content; there a parent could object to the content while the writer would see the objection as cover for the identity. The distinction holds as a principle, but real disagreement lives in the cases the writer did not pick.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The opener argues that protecting children from genuine harm and shielding them from the existence of people unlike themselves are different acts, and that confusing the two carries a long-term cost. Write an essay that argues a position on the following claim: Adults charged with the welfare of children have a duty to expose them to perspectives and lives different from their own, even when that exposure makes the adults uncomfortable. In your response you should develop your argument with specific evidence and reasoning, examine the strongest version of the opposing view, and qualify your position where the evidence calls for it. You may draw on your reading, observation, knowledge, or experience; you are not required to use the facts in the opener.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may read the opening concession as the writer's actual thesis and conclude the piece supports book restrictions. Tie this to the marked Antithesis in paragraph two: the writer grants protection from harm in order to set it against protection from difference, not to endorse removal. The concession is a starting move in a dialectic, not the conclusion.
- Students may mistake the Tango example for proof that no book should ever be removed for any reason. The marked Logos move reasons that one specific obscenity charge is a cover; it does not claim every objection everywhere is illegitimate, and reading it that way is the over-broad trap the MCQ also tests.
- Students may label the parallel 'protection from harm... protection from difference' as anaphora because it repeats. It is antithesis built on parallelism: the repeated element ('protection from') is part of a balanced contrast of opposed ideas, and the repetition sits inside the structure rather than only at the start of successive clauses.
- Students may treat the forty-percent and ninety-two-percent figures as the argument itself rather than as evidence inside a chain of reasoning. The statistics support inferences (the rationale is a cover; the duty has moved from parents to campaigns); they are the anecdotal-versus-statistical pairing's quantitative half, not standalone claims.

AP exam alignment:

This opener teaches students to follow a dialectical argument that reasons forward from a shared premise to a resisted conclusion, and to see how a sincere concession functions as persuasive ground rather than retreat. It models reading evidence (a single telling example paired with aggregate statistics) as steps in a line of reasoning, and it sharpens the parallelism-versus-antithesis distinction and the analysis of a restrained, inward-turning tone.